

"Cycle for Two" : How Menstrual Awareness Improves Empathy and Communication in Relationships

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Abstract

This study examines the impact of the menstrual cycle on intimate relationships, focusing on both partners who menstruate and those who do not. The project aimed to include heterosexual and homosexual couples, where at least one partner menstruates and does not use hormonal contraceptives. Four couples received "Cycle for Two" kits, which featured open-ended questions, personal journals, drawing activities, body maps, and menstrual hygiene products. Initial interviews provided early insights. Despite some logistical challenges, the findings indicate that menstrual cycle awareness significantly affects relationship dynamics, emotional understanding, and partner support. The study suggests that "Cycle for Two" can foster empathy and enhance communication in intimate relationships. It also offers practical ideas for relationship counseling and developing more inclusive and supportive menstrual tracking apps.

Keywords: Cultural Probe, Menstruation, Cycle sharing, Feminist HCI

1. Introduction

The menstrual cycle is a natural and crucial aspect of many people's lives, yet its impact on intimate relationships remains poorly understood [1]. While much research has focused on individual experiences of menstruation, the dynamics between menstruating and non-menstruating partners, particularly how they feel and interact, are less explored. Often considered taboo, menstruation can lead to misunderstandings, lack of support, and emotional strain between partners [1][8]. Addressing this, our study explores how increased awareness and open discussions of the menstrual cycle could enhance relationship dynamics, emotional understanding, and support among partners.

Open communication and understanding are vital for maintaining emotional health and happiness in close relationships. However, discussing menstruation can often be uncomfortable, resulting in a lack of support between partners. Recognizing the potential of cycle-tracking applications, which have gained popularity for managing menstrual cycles [2], this study also examines their role in intimate relationships. Although these applications are helpful, they frequently do not engage both partners effectively, missing opportunities to foster mutual understanding and support. This gap can leave menstruating partners feeling unsupported when sharing information about their cycle, highlighting the need for more inclusive features and activities that promote engagement and support through cycle-sharing.

Therefore, this study specifically aims to explore the impact of cycle-sharing on partner interactions during different stages of the menstrual cycle (RQ 1) and to identify essential features

or activities that should be incorporated into the cycle-sharing process to support the physical and menstrual health of couples (SubQ 1). The research seeks to develop insights and recommendations for more inclusive and supportive activities by investigating these aspects.

To investigate these dynamics, we employed cultural probes [8][9] as a research method, aiming to uncover detailed experiences and interactions related to menstruation within intimate relationships [1]. Conducted over ten days, this study allowed participants to engage with "Cycle for Two" kits during different phases of their menstrual cycle. This flexible approach was necessary to accommodate the individualized nature of menstruation.

The initial phase of our research involved preliminary interviews to gather baseline insights and establish rapport with the participants. After distributing the kits, we eagerly awaited their return, which would be filled with participants' reflections, drawings, and responses. Despite some logistical challenges, this method proved effective in uncovering deep and nuanced insights into how menstrual cycle awareness can affect intimate relationships.

By the end of our research, we had gathered a wealth of data that underscored the positive impacts of menstrual cycle awareness on relationship dynamics, emotional understanding, and partner support. Our findings highlight the potential of cultural probes to foster empathy and communication within intimate relationships, offering valuable implications for relationship counseling and the design of menstrual tracking applications that are more inclusive and supportive.

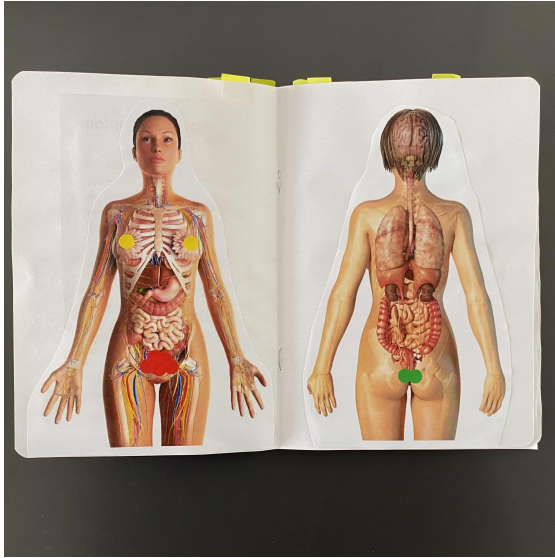


Figure 2: Body Map Exercise



Figure 3: "Cycle for Two" Kit

Individual Journals: Each partner received a personal journal containing three questions focused on their feelings and experiences related to menstruation. These journals allowed for private reflection and provided a space for participants to document their thoughts without the pressure of sharing them immediately.

Emotion Wheel: We gave our participants an "emotion wheel," which is a round chart showing different emotions. We asked them to color the emotions they felt toward their partner during menstruation (Figure 4).

Drawings and Pencils: A drawing challenge was included to encourage participants to express their perceptions of their partner during menstruation non-verbally. Drawing can reveal insights that words might not capture, offering a different medium for understanding and empathy.

Body Map: One of the notebooks contained a body map with colorful stickers for highlighting areas of physical discomfort. This exercise involved the non-menstruating partner asking their partner about physical sensations and challenges related to the menstrual cycle. By providing five colors of stickers without specific instructions on their meanings, participants could assign their significance, allowing for personalized expression and analysis of patterns (Figure 2).

Menstrual Hygiene Products: The kits included various menstrual hygiene products to encourage interaction and highlight the importance of menstrual hygiene. Despite potential discomfort or initial hesitation, this component aimed to emphasize the significance of these products in daily menstrual management.

Affirmation Stickers: Empty stickers were provided for participants to write affirmations for themselves and each other. This activity aimed to promote self-care and mutual support, acknowledging the emotional and psychological aspects of navigating menstruation together.

3.1. Participants and recruitment process

Participants were recruited through online platforms and personal networks, including social media, group chats, and student housing groups. We targeted couples residing in Salzburg, Austria, with at least one partner who menstruates and is not using hormonal contraceptives. The exclusion of hormonal contraceptives ensured that natural menstrual cycles were central to our investigation.

Despite initial challenges in recruiting diverse couples, we successfully included one homosexual couple by expanding our outreach efforts through friends and family. In total, we selected three heterosexual couples from Salzburg and one homosexual couple who participated online. Participants ranged in age from 22 to 42 years and were in monogamous relationships, providing a diverse range of experiences and insights.

3.2. Getting "Cycle for Two" KITs back

The collection of the kits (Figure 3) was done individually with each couple. During these interactions, we gathered feedback on their experiences with the activities and took detailed notes. While there was initial concern about receiving incomplete or empty kits, participants generally reported that the activities were enjoyable and insightful.

Follow-up conversations revealed that participants felt more confident and open about discussing menstruation. They reported learning new things about each other, with some noting that the activities served as a reminder of the emotional and physical aspects of menstruation. This feedback suggests that cultural probes can effectively facilitate open conversations and increase comfort around discussing menstruation.

One of the couples did not return their kit.

4. Data analysis

We employed two complementary methods for data analysis: thematic analysis [11] for text-based exercises and an Affinity

Cluster 3: Communication and Support: Open Communication: Importance of discussing menstruation openly. Support Needs: Need for support during emotional lows and physical discomfort. Understanding and Empathy: Increased understanding and empathy from non-menstruating partners.

Cluster 4: Menstrual Hygiene Products: Awareness: Increased awareness of the importance and use of menstrual hygiene products

5. Discussions

Our study provides insights into the dynamics of the menstrual cycle within intimate relationships. By employing a combination of thematic analysis and Affinity diagram, we integrated findings through a cross-analysis approach, and we have been able to capture a comprehensive picture of how menstrual awareness impacts relationships.

Emotional Variability: One important finding of our research is the range of emotions felt by both menstruating and non-menstruating partners. Both written and visual data show that it is important to notice and talk about these changing emotions to build empathy and support in relationships. The emotional wheel exercise was especially helpful because it visually showed these feelings, making it easier for partners to talk about and understand each other's experiences. This finding shows the need for open communication about emotions and support during the menstrual cycle.

Menstrual Hygiene Awareness: Increased awareness and understanding of menstrual hygiene products were clear from both the written responses and visual activities. This awareness helped open discussions about menstrual hygiene, a topic that is often uncomfortable and surrounded by stigma. Including different menstrual products in the kits encouraged practical learning and mutual engagement, showing how important these products are in improving relationships. This suggests that teaching about menstrual hygiene should be part of relationship counseling and support programs.

Communication and Support: The study's findings clearly show that open communication and support are very important for dealing with menstrual-related challenges in relationships. Thematic analysis showed that open-ended questions and reflective journals greatly improved communication between partners. Visual analysis supported this, as activities like the body map and drawing challenge helped remove barriers and promote empathy. These insights highlight the value of structured activities and tools that make it easier to talk about sensitive topics, leading to deeper mutual understanding and support.

Physical Discomfort and Pain Points: The body map exercise helped show common pain points during menstruation. Both written and visual data confirmed that recognizing and addressing these physical discomforts can improve support and empathy from non-menstruating partners. This activity also showed how important practical tools are for understanding relationships. Future designs of menstrual tracking apps and educational programs should include features that help partners understand and address physical discomforts associated with menstruation.

Our findings also supported the information participants provided to us before and after the research. Here are some quotes from our participants:

Couple 1

Before: "I have lived with my boyfriend for 4 years, and we talk openly about menstruation."

After: "That was so much fun! We liked the project and spending time together. Even though we were open about menstruation, I think now he understands more."

Couple 2

Before: "We have been married for 10 years, and we are used to conversations about menstruation. But I'm curious if we can learn more about the subject."

After: "That was so much fun, especially telling my partner about the pain points and symptoms I feel during the cycle. Now I may consider using the cycle-sharing feature because I feel the activities brought us closer."

Couple 3

Before: "We live in different countries and I don't think it is necessary"

After: "Since we see each other rarely, I never felt the importance of sharing, but after doing all exercises together, especially the body map, I would think about sharing information to get some support."

Couple 4 - did not return their kit.

6. Future Research Directions and Limitation:

Future research may continue to explore the dynamics of medical limitations trial cycle awareness within intimate relationships, incorporating larger and more diverse samples to validate and expand upon these findings. Additionally, combining cultural probes with other qualitative and quantitative methods could provide deeper insights into the multifaceted impact of menstruation on relationships.

There is also an unresearched area of cycle-sharing feature in period tracking apps we have not been able to explore carefully due to limited time. We gathered insights from our participants which seem potentially interesting for upcoming research. For example, in general, participants who used cycle-tracking apps found them useful for managing their menstrual cycles and appreciated sharing this information with their doctors. However, they never considered using a cycle-sharing feature with their partner. Occasionally we asked their opinion on cycle sharing app before and after the probe:

Couple 1 "I use a cycle-tracking app, but I don't use cycle-sharing features. Maybe I'll consider using the cycle-sharing feature in the future."

Couple 2

"No, I have never used the cycle-sharing feature. But now I may consider using the cycle-sharing feature because I feel the activities brought us closer."

While interest in cycle-sharing features varied among participants, we would be interested in exploring barriers to using a cycle-sharing app from both sides and exploring the long-term effect on the presumption of the period in a relationship.

The cultural probe study was initially planned to span two weeks, designed to coincide with the luteal and menstrual phases of the participants' cycles. However, due to the practical challenges of synchronizing the study schedule with the varying menstrual phases of the participants, this approach proved to be overly complex. Additionally, time constraints made it impractical to wait for each menstruating participant to enter the appropriate phase. As a result, we adapted the research timeline, shortening the study to a more manageable ten days. This adjustment shifted the focus from aligning with specific menstrual phases to emphasizing the overall experience of each couple.

Using a cultural probe to explore cycle sharing, we recognized that merely observing data and gathering insights from drawings and answers may be insufficient for such a sensitive topic. It seems we might lack a comprehensive understanding of the participant's circumstances and motivations for participation.

Although using the cultural probe method had its benefits, we faced some problems. It was hard to understand the results and how much effort participants put into the exercises. We had questions like, "Did participants try their best?" or "Do they dislike drawing, or do they think the exercise is pointless?" These uncertainties made our data unclear.

Our limited experience with cultural probes and the short project time stopped us from understanding the results better. In future projects, we plan to use interviews or include face-to-face activities to see how participants interact and react in real-time.

One of the major limitations of our project was the lack of diversity among participants. Although we included one homosexual couple to enrich our study, we never received their Kit back, which leaves a gap in our research. The absence of diverse perspectives, which are crucial for comprehensive research, makes our findings less conclusive [7].

Practical Implications: The findings from this study have several practical implications for relationship counseling, educational programs, and the design of menstrual health technologies. Speaking of HCI, research on the menstrual cycle plays an important role in the FemTech industry and growing field of research from a feminist perspective. It may contain all possible design detection it can go to explore different sides of menstruation to support people who menstruate in this part of their life. Based on the paper, we would suggest several paths for exploring it further — creating a gamified process where people can openly and regularly check with their partners about different aspects, especially menstruation.

7. Summary and conclusions

This study explores the dynamics of the menstrual cycle within intimate relationships, highlighting how menstrual awareness impacts emotional understanding and partner support. Using cultural probes, we gathered data through open-ended questions, journals, drawing activities, body maps, and menstrual hygiene products, which facilitated open discussions and mutual learning.

After analyzing all the data, we concluded that while menstruating partners do discuss menstruation with their partners,

some topics remain too shy to talk about. However, the "Cycle for Two" activities have facilitated more open discussions about menstruation. Additionally, menstruating partners expressed a desire for more support and understanding from their non-menstruating partners throughout the cycle. Couples also noted the benefits of the educational aspect of the process. Knowing that their non-menstruating partners will take the information seriously and offer support and comfort makes menstruating partners feel more comfortable sharing information about menstruation.

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